

■ JNTUK R23 • SEMESTER II • ENGLISH

Human Values

Unit 1 — The Gift of the Magi & Language Skills

REGULATION

JNTUK R23

SEMESTER

II

REFERENCE

Pathfinder

*"Of all who give gifts these two were the wisest. They are the Magi." — O.
Henry*

1 Author Introduction



William Sydney Porter

Pen Name: O. Henry | (1862 – 1910)

O. Henry was a prolific American short-story writer renowned for his realistic portrayal of ordinary city life, wry humour, and trademark **surprise endings** — a literary device so distinctive it became known as the "O. Henry twist." Born in Greensboro, North Carolina, he worked various jobs before discovering his gift for storytelling.

His stories blend **pathos and humour**, focusing on middle-class people with sympathy and understanding. *The Gift of the Magi* is one of his most celebrated works and perfectly captures his style: a simple, moving story carrying a profound moral message about love and sacrifice.

us American Writer

Short Stories

Surprise Endings

City Life

WRITING STYLE OF O. HENRY

- **Wry Humour:** Gentle irony mixed with sentimental emotion.
- **Realistic Detail:** Vivid descriptions of everyday life and struggles.
- **Surprise Twist Ending:** An unexpected but logical conclusion that reframes the story.
- **Sympathetic Characters:** Ordinary people with extraordinary hearts.
- **Moral Core:** Every story carries a human value — love, sacrifice, or integrity.

2 Summary of the Lesson

"The Gift of the Magi" — O. Henry

Della and Jim Young are a young, poor couple deeply in love, living in a modest furnished flat for \$8 a week. Christmas is approaching and Della has only **\$1.87** to buy Jim a gift. She is heartbroken.

"One dollar and eighty-seven cents. That was all. And sixty cents of it was in pennies... Three times Della counted it. One dollar and eighty-seven cents. And the next day would be Christmas."

The couple has two prized possessions: **Jim's gold watch** (a family heirloom) and **Della's long, beautiful brown hair**. In an act of pure love, Della sells her hair to Madame Sofronie for **\$20**. She uses the money to buy Jim a **platinum fob chain** for his watch.

When Jim comes home and sees Della's short hair, he is stunned — not with anger, but shock. He hands her his present: **a set of beautiful tortoiseshell combs** she had longed for — bought with the money he received from **selling his gold watch**.

THE IRONIC TWIST

Jim sold his watch to buy combs for Della's hair. Della sold her hair to buy a chain for Jim's watch. Each sacrificed their most precious possession for the other — and both gifts became temporarily useless. Yet the gesture reveals the depth of their love.

★ Key Moral / Human Values

- True love involves — giving up what is most precious for another.
- Material possessions are less important than the .
- O. Henry calls Della and Jim the wisest gift-givers — like the biblical Magi.
- Poverty does not diminish the richness of a loving heart.
- Real wealth is measured in .

3 Grammar & Language Skills

A. Writing Skills

CAPITAL LETTERS — RULES

Rule	Example
First word of every sentence	<i>The story is set in New York.</i>
Names of people and places	<i>Della, Jim, New York, Broadway</i>
Days, months, holidays, religions	<i>Christmas, Sunday, March, Islam</i>
Nationalities and languages	<i>Indian, Hindi, Japanese, Spanish</i>
Titles used with names	<i>Dr Rahman, Mrs Shetty, Professor Rao</i>
Names of organisations / institutions	<i>NIT Rourkela, Punjab Technical University</i>

Rule	Example
Brands, vehicles, spacecraft	Maruti, Boeing 747, Rajdhani, Apollo

PUNCTUATION MARKS

Mark	Name	Use	Example
.	Full Stop / Period	End of statement sentence	<i>I went to college this morning.</i>
,	Comma	List items, join clauses, non-restrictive info	<i>You may choose apples, bananas, or pears.</i>
:	Colon	Introduce a list or explanation	<i>Vijaya played several sports: hockey, basketball.</i>
;	Semicolon	Link two related independent clauses	<i>She refused to give up; she had worked too hard.</i>
'	Apostrophe	Show possession or contractions	<i>Vijaya's cap; it's = it is; didn't = did not</i>

⚠ COMMON MISTAKES TO AVOID

- Do NOT use apostrophe for plurals: *X dog's* (plural) → ✓ *dogs*
- Do NOT confuse *it's* (it is) with *its* (possession)
- Do NOT use apostrophe for personal pronouns: *X your's* → ✓ *yours*
- Sentence fragment: always include a subject + predicate

B. Reading Skills — Skimming & Scanning

👁 SKIMMING

Reading quickly to get the **overall idea** (gist) of a text. You don't read every word — just enough to understand the main topic and structure.

Use when: Deciding if an article is relevant; reviewing before a detailed read.

🔍 SCANNING

Looking for **specific information** in a text — a name, date, or number. You know what you're looking for before you begin.

Use when: Finding a word in a dictionary; looking up a phone number.

SAMPLE COMPREHENSION QUESTIONS (FROM THE STORY)

Q Scan: Who gave Jim his watch?

Answer: Jim's watch had been his **father's and grandfather's** — it was a family heirloom (passed down to him).

Q Scan: What colour were the combs Jim gifted Della?

Answer: The combs were **tortoiseshell**, pure and beautiful with jewelled rims.

Q Skim: What is the central theme of the story?

Answer: The central theme is **selfless love and sacrifice**. Both Jim and Della gave up their most prized possessions to show how much they cared for each other.

4 Main Lesson — Detailed Explanation

4.1 The Setting and Characters

The story is set in **New York City** in a modest, furnished flat. The couple — **James Dillingham Young (Jim)** and his wife **Della** — live on \$20 a week (reduced from \$30), barely making ends meet. Their flat costs \$8/week. Their names reflect their economic slide: "Dillingham" shrank visually on the letterbox as their income shrank.

- **Della:** A loving, resourceful, and spontaneous woman. She saves every penny but cannot save enough.
- **Jim:** A serious, thin young man of 22 who bears financial burdens quietly. He is thoughtful and deeply caring.

4.2 The Two Treasures

JIM'S GOLD WATCH

A family heirloom passed from grandfather to father to Jim. It was worthy of King Solomon's admiration. Jim wore it on a cheap leather strap — not a worthy chain.

DELLA'S BROWN HAIR

Long, rippling hair that fell below her knee — "like a cascade of brown waters." Had the Queen of Sheba lived nearby, her jewels would have paled in comparison.

4.3 Della's Sacrifice

Della sells her beautiful hair to **Madame Sofronie** ("Hair Goods of All Kinds") for **\$20**. She spends \$21 total — buying a simple, elegant **platinum fob chain** for Jim's watch. She returns home and

uses curling irons to style her short hair into tiny curls, worrying Jim won't find her pretty.

4.4 Jim's Sacrifice

Unknown to Della, Jim had already sold his prized gold watch to buy her a gift. He bought the **beautiful tortoiseshell combs with jewelled rims** that Della had admired in a Broadway shop window for years but never hoped to own.

4.5 The Climax and Resolution

When Jim arrives and sees Della's short hair, he is momentarily stunned — not from disappointment, but because he now understands the **cruel irony**: the combs he bought are for hair that is gone; the chain she bought is for a watch that is sold.

Jim's tender response: *"Dell, let's put our Christmas presents away and keep 'em awhile. I sold the watch to get the money to buy your combs."*

O. Henry concludes that these two "foolish children" are actually the wisest — because they gave from the heart. **They are the Magi.**

★ Key Takeaways

- The title "Gift of the Magi" links the couple to the wise men (Magi) who brought gifts to Baby Jesus.
- The story uses — both gifts became useless, yet both were priceless in meaning.
- O. Henry's "twist": realising both sacrificed for each other simultaneously.
- The author uses biblical allusions (Queen of Sheba, King Solomon, the Magi) to elevate the couple's love.
- Real wisdom is not material; it lies in selfless, unconditional love.

5 Speaking — Introducing Oneself & Others

This unit teaches how to introduce yourself and others in both **formal** and **informal** settings.

Situation	Formal	Informal
Introducing yourself	<i>Good morning! I'm Prakash Reddy. I'm the new history teacher.</i>	<i>Hello. I'm John. I'm Joseph's brother.</i>
Responding	<i>Pleased to meet you. Welcome to the National School.</i>	<i>Hi! Nice to meet you.</i>
Introducing others	<i>Akash, I'd like to introduce Mr Prakash Reddy to you.</i>	<i>Kamala, meet my colleague Sagar.</i>

USEFUL POINTS TO REMEMBER

- Be brief and clear when introducing yourself.
- In formal settings, give your full name; in informal settings, first name is enough.
- Do NOT use titles (Mr, Dr, Ms) before your OWN name.
- In formal settings, a junior is always introduced to a senior.
- A man is introduced to a woman in formal social settings.

Useful Expressions

Let me introduce myself...

Good morning! My name is...

I'd like to introduce... to you.

Pleased to meet you.

May I introduce... (formal)

Nice meeting you too.

I'm from... / I work for...

I have just joined / moved in...

6 Vocabulary — Word Roots, Prefixes & Suffixes

6.1 Important Glossary from the Story

parsimony

miserliness; extreme stinginess

vestibule

lobby; entrance hall

mendicancy squad

people who make a living by begging

pier glass

a tall mirror between windows

cascade

a small waterfall; flowing motion

meretricious

superficially attractive; showy and false

ransack

to search thoroughly

fob chain

chain for a pocket watch

ecstatic

full of joy; extremely happy

mammoth task

a very long and difficult task

bulldoze

to force someone to agree by pressure

on the sly

secretly

6.2 Common Word Roots (Greek & Latin)

Root	Meaning	Examples
bio	life	biology, biography
chrono	time	chronology, synchronise
geo	earth	geography, geology
graph / gram	write / record	autograph, telegram
phil	love	philosophy, bibliophile
phobia	fear of	claustrophobia, xenophobia
scope	observe, watch	telescope, microscope
dict	speak	dictate, verdict
port	carry	transport, portable
mal	evil, badly	malnourished, malevolent

6.3 Key Prefixes & Suffixes

PREFIXES

Prefix	Meaning	Example
un-	not	unusual, unhappy
pre-	before	preview, precedent
re-	again	rewrite, regain
mis-	wrong	misspell, misinterpret
dis-	not/opposite	discover, disown
inter-	between	international, intercept

SUFFIXES

Suffix	Meaning	Example
-ness	state/quality of being	greatness, sadness
-ment	state of / action of	movement, contentment
-less	without, lacking	pitiless, tireless
-ful	full of	beautiful, peaceful
-tion / -ion	state of something	elation, depression
-ist	person who does	philanthropist, artist

Human Values in Daily Life

The story of Jim and Della illustrates several core human values that engineering students must cultivate — both professionally and personally.

EMPATHY

Understanding and sharing the feelings of another. Della imagined Jim's joy in receiving a worthy chain — this drove her sacrifice.

Real-life application: A good engineer listens to the user's needs before designing a solution.

INTEGRITY

Doing the right thing even when no one is watching. Jim could have kept his money — instead he quietly sacrificed his prized watch.

Real-life application: In the workplace, integrity means honest reporting and ethical conduct.

SELFLESSNESS

Putting others' needs before your own. Both characters prioritised each other's happiness over their own treasured possessions.

Real-life application: A team player shares credit and resources for collective success.

COURAGE

Della needed courage to cut her most beautiful feature. Real love takes courage — so does speaking truth in difficult situations.

Real-life application: Reporting a safety issue at work, even under pressure.

8 Exam Tips



Answer Writing Strategy

Always begin short answers with a one-line direct answer, then expand with 2–3 supporting sentences. End with the significance.



Common Mistakes to Avoid

Do not confuse Jim's and Della's gifts. Jim sold the *watch* → bought combs. Della sold her *hair* → bought the chain.



Time Management



Long Answer Structure

Short answers: 5–7 min each. Long answers: 15–20 min each. Save 5 min to review spelling and punctuation.

Introduction → Explanation with 2–3 points → Examples from text → Conclusion with moral. Always relate to Human Values.

☀️ GOLDEN RULES FOR ENGLISH EXAM

- Use **topic sentences** to begin each paragraph in long answers.
- Quote the story sparingly but accurately to support your points.
- For grammar questions — read the whole sentence before answering.
- In vocabulary questions, use context clues before guessing.
- For comprehension, underline keywords in the question first, then scan the passage.

9 Short Answer Questions (with Answers)

 Write answers in approximately 50–60 words each

1 Who were the Youngs, and what were the two possessions they were proud of?

Jim and Della Young were a young married couple living in a modest New York flat on \$20 a week. Their two prized possessions were **Jim's gold pocket watch** — a family heirloom passed from his grandfather and father — and **Della's long, beautiful brown hair**, which rippled like a cascade of brown waters below her knee.

2 What had Jim done to give a gift to his wife?

Jim sacrificed his most treasured possession — his **gold watch** — to give Della a meaningful Christmas gift. He sold the watch and used the money to buy a **set of beautiful tortoiseshell combs with jewelled rims** that Della had admired in a Broadway shop window for a long time but could never afford.

3 What did Della do with her hair and why?

Della **sold her beautiful long hair** to Madame Sofronie, a hair-goods shopkeeper, for **\$20**. She did this because she had only \$1.87 saved and desperately wanted to buy Jim a worthy Christmas present. With the money, she purchased an elegant **platinum fob chain** for Jim's beloved gold watch.

4 What was Della's reaction on receiving the gift that Jim got for her?

Della was first **ecstatically joyful** — she screamed with delight when she saw the tortoiseshell combs. But immediately she was overcome with a mix of emotions and broke into **hysterical tears**, realising the painful irony: the combs were for her beautiful hair — which she had just sold. She hugged them close and smiled bravely.

5 What is the significance of the title "The Gift of the Magi"?

The Magi were the three wise men who brought precious gifts to the infant Jesus. O. Henry compares Jim and Della to the Magi because they, too, gave the **wisest possible gifts** — gifts born from **true selfless love**. Although their gifts became practically useless, the love behind them made Jim and Della the wisest gift-givers of all.

6 How did O. Henry reveal the couple's financial difficulty?

O. Henry reveals their poverty through vivid details: **Della counting her pennies three times** (\$1.87 total), the **\$8-per-week flat** with a non-functioning doorbell, the name "Dillingham" shrinking on the letterbox as income fell, and Jim wearing his fine watch on a cheap leather strap instead of a proper chain.

7 What is skimming? How is it different from scanning?

Skimming is reading a text quickly to understand its *general idea or gist* — without focusing on every word. **Scanning**, on the other hand, means looking for *specific information* (a name, date, or figure) in a text, where you already know what you're searching for. Skimming gives overview; scanning gives targeted details.

10 Long Answer Questions (with Answers)

 Write answers in approximately 200 words each

1 How do Jim's and Della's actions symbolise the strength of their love for each other?

Jim and Della's story is one of the most touching depictions of selfless love in literature. Each character independently makes the **ultimate sacrifice** — giving up their most prized possession to make the other happy.

Della's hair is her greatest natural beauty. She takes great pride in it; even the Queen of Sheba's jewels would not compare. Yet without hesitation, she sells it to Madame Sofronie for \$20 — spending everything on a **platinum fob chain** worthy of Jim's gold watch. Her motive is pure: to bring dignity and joy to her husband.

Jim, equally unknown to Della, has sold the watch — a cherished family heirloom representing three generations — to buy Della the tortoiseshell combs she had longed for. He too acts from a place of deep love, not logic.

The supreme irony is that each gift has been rendered temporarily useless: Della has no hair for the combs; Jim has no watch for the chain. Yet O. Henry argues this makes them **wiser than the Magi**, because their gifts are not things — they are expressions of a love that transcends material value.

Their actions teach us that love, at its truest, does not calculate cost. It gives freely, completely, and joyfully — even at personal loss.

2 Write a detailed note on the different ways in which O. Henry tells readers about the financial situation of the couple.

O. Henry uses a range of literary techniques to convey the **grinding poverty** of Jim and Della, making it feel painfully real without ever being melodramatic.

Direct Statement: The story opens with Della counting her savings — \$1.87 — three times, with sixty cents in pennies. The repetition of this small figure emphasises the hopelessness of her situation just before Christmas.

The Flat: Their furnished apartment costs \$8 a week. The vestibule's broken doorbell and the name "Dillingham" on the card (once proudly full, now seemingly embarrassed as income fell from \$30 to \$20 a week) are subtle but powerful details.

Ironic Arithmetic: "Eight dollars a week or a million a year — what is the difference?" O. Henry uses this line to mock the gap between their reality and aspirations.

The Grocers and Butchers: Della "bulldozing the grocer and the vegetable man and the butcher" for the pennies — suggesting she haggles every purchase, carefully managing a meagre budget.

Jim's Appearance: He is described as thin, serious, needing a new overcoat, without gloves — all telling signs of financial hardship in a cold winter city.

Together, these details paint a picture not of despair, but of dignified poverty — a couple rich in love despite having almost nothing.

3 Discuss the human values demonstrated in "The Gift of the Magi" with relevant examples.

"The Gift of the Magi" is a profound study in human values — qualities that elevate us above the merely material and connect us to our highest moral potential.

1. Selfless Sacrifice: Both Jim and Della sacrifice their most precious possessions — not forced, not reluctantly, but with joy and love. Della's sale of her hair and Jim's sale of his watch represent giving at its purest: expecting nothing in return.

2. Empathy: Each character deeply understands what the other values. Della knows the watch needs a worthy chain; Jim knows Della has coveted the combs. This understanding of the other's inner world is true empathy in action.

3. Courage: It takes courage to cut off one's hair and walk into a shop to sell it. Della falters briefly — "a tear or two splashed on the worn red carpet" — but proceeds. Jim too faces the world without his heirloom watch.

4. Gratitude and Grace: Despite the irony of their gifts, neither Jim nor Della responds with disappointment. Jim enfolds Della warmly; Della hugs her combs with tears of joy. This grace under difficult circumstances is itself a human value.

O. Henry uses the metaphor of the Magi — the three wise men — to elevate Jim and Della's ordinary act into a timeless lesson: the greatest gifts are those given from the heart.

11 Previous Year Questions

JNTUK Pattern

1 Who were the Youngs? What were the two things they prided in?

Short Q

Jim and Della Young were a young couple living in a small New York flat. **Jim prided in his gold watch**, a three-generation heirloom, and **Della prided in her long, beautiful brown hair** that flowed to below her knee. These were their two greatest treasures, and ironically the very things they sacrificed for love.

2 What did Della do with her hair and why?

Short Q

Della sold her long, rippling brown hair to Madame Sofronie for \$20 because she had only \$1.87 saved — far too little to buy Jim a worthy Christmas gift. She sacrificed her most prized personal possession out of deep love, using the proceeds to purchase a platinum fob chain for Jim's cherished gold watch.

3 How do Jim's and Della's actions symbolise the strength of their love?

Long Q

Jim and Della's story powerfully symbolises love through **mutual, simultaneous sacrifice**. Without knowing what the other had done, both sold their most valued possessions to make the other happy on Christmas. Jim sold his gold watch (a three-generation heirloom) to buy Della the tortoiseshell combs she craved; Della sold her beautiful long hair to buy Jim a platinum watch chain.

The poignant irony — that each gift is now temporarily unusable — does not diminish their love. Rather, it magnifies it. O. Henry concludes that such sacrificial giving is the highest

form of wisdom. Like the Magi who gave gifts to the Christ child, these two "foolish children" gave the only thing that truly matters: their whole hearts.

4 Explain the rules of using capital letters in English with examples.

Grammar Q

Capital letters are used in the following cases:

- First word of every sentence: *The story begins in New York.*
- Names of people, places, streets: *Della, Broadway, Nehru Marg*
- Days, months, holidays: *Sunday, Christmas, Diwali, March*
- Nationalities and languages: *Indian, Hindi, English, Japanese*
- Titles with names: *Dr Prakash, Mrs Shetty*
- Names of institutions and organisations: *Vimala College, NIT Rourkela*
- Brands and vehicle names: *Maruti, Boeing 747, Rajdhani*
- Religious books: *the Bible, the Quran, the Bhagavad Gita*

5 What is the difference between skimming and scanning? Give examples.

Reading Q

Skimming means reading quickly to understand the general idea or gist of a text. You don't read every word — just enough to get an overview. For example, flipping through a newspaper to decide which articles to read fully.

Scanning means searching for specific information that you already know you're looking for — a name, date, or fact. For example, looking up a phone number in a directory or finding the meaning of a word in a dictionary.

Key difference: *Skimming* → *What is this about?* | *Scanning* → *Where is the specific detail I need?*



Conclusion — Unit 1

Unit 1 of JNTUK R23 English takes us on a journey into the heart of human values through O. Henry's timeless classic. Jim and Della's story is more than a Christmas tale — it is a mirror held up to the best of what humanity can be: loving, giving, courageous, and wise.

"Of all who give and receive gifts, such as they are wisest. Everywhere they are wisest. They are the Magi." — O. Henry

As you prepare for your exams, remember that the purpose of learning English is not just grammar and vocabulary — it is to become a more thoughtful, articulate, and empathetic human being. Carry these values forward into your engineering career and life.

★ *Best wishes for your examinations — Study smart, write clearly, and let your values shine through your words.* ★